

Dvar Torah Outline — Hilchot Seder Night: “אין מפטירים אחר הפסח אפיקומן,” Drinking After Afikoman, and the Joyful Avodah of the Night

Abstract

Rabbi Shulman explains the halachah of **not eating or drinking after the fourth cup**, rooted in “אין מפטירים אחר הפסח אפיקומן,” so that the taste of the מצה (as זכר לקרבן פסח) remains in one’s mouth. He clarifies why the **third and fourth cups** do not contradict this rule—because they are themselves **mitzvah-drinking**—and why additional flavored drinks (even more wine) are still prohibited, with **water** as the primary exception. Rabbi Shulman concludes by emphasizing the larger the seder night should be lived with: **simchah, clarity, and song**, ideally extending through the night for those able to do so.

I. The core halachah: preserving “טעם מצה” after the fourth cup

A. The halachic statement (פרק ס"ה)

- After **כוס רביעי**, one may not eat or drink so that the **taste of the מצה** remains.
- Rabbi Shulman anchors this in the Gemara’s formulation:
 - “אין מפטירים אחר הפסח אפיקומן”
 - (One does not “conclude” after the korban Pesach with dessert/other foods.)
- Extension to our practice:
 - Since we no longer have a **קרבן פסח**, the **מצה** functions as **זכר לקרבן פסח**.

B. Drinking is included (not only eating)

- Rabbi Shulman explains the logic:
 - Just as eating other foods removes/diminishes the taste, **drinking** does as well.
 - Framing:
 - The problem is not merely “replacing” the taste, but **diminishing** it.
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II. The challenge: how can we drink cups 3 and 4 after eating? (1:00)

A. The question

- Rabbi Shulman raises the difficulty:
 - If drinking diminishes the taste of מצה, then כוס שלישי (on ברכת המזון) and כוס רביעי (on הלל) are both drunk **after** eating מצה—so why are they allowed?

B. The answer: mitzvah-drinking is different

- Key distinction:
 - “שאני התם, דמצוה הם”
(It’s different there, because those cups are a mitzvah.)
- Practical rule Rabbi Shulman extracts:
 - The prohibition targets דברים של רשות (optional food/drink), not items consumed **as part of the mitzvah structure** of the seder.

C. Brief note on כוס חמישי

- Rabbi Shulman notes that there is discussion about a **fifth cup**, and frames its permissibility (on the side that it is practiced) under the same principle:
 - If it is treated as a **mitzvah-cup**, it would not violate the concern of “...אין מפטירים”.

III. Which drinks are prohibited—and why water is different (3:39)

A. The baseline: other drinking is אסור after afikoman

- Rabbi Shulman summarizes:
 - **All other drinking is prohibited** because it diminishes the taste of מצה.

B. Exception: water

- Reason given:
 - Water has no taste, so it does not displace/diminish the taste of the מצה.
 - “וכיון שאין בהם טעם אינם מוציא טעם מצה ומותר”
(Since it has no flavor, it does not remove the taste of the matzah, and it is permitted.)

C. The ruling of the Rif and Rambam: flavored drinks (including wine) interfere

- Rabbi Shulman cites the psak that **wine** is prohibited after afikoman (beyond the required cups):
 - Any **drink with flavor** will negate/diminish the taste of the מצה.
- He adds a clear application:
 - Even “a few extra sips” of wine after completing the required cups would be **אסור**, because it is not part of the mitzvah.

D. Minhag framing

- Rabbi Shulman notes that this is presented as:
 - “**וכך הוא המנהג וכך ראוי**”
(This is the custom, and this is proper.)
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IV. The broader avodah of the night: telling the story with joy and clarity (6:30)

A. The value of extended sippur yetziat mitzrayim

- Rabbi Shulman emphasizes:
 - “**מצוה גדולה לספר ביציאת מצרים כל הלילה**”
(It is a great mitzvah to tell of the Exodus all night.)
- Model from the Haggadah:
 - The elders in בני ברק who spoke all night **until the time for קריאת שמע of the morning**.

B. Realistic guidance: not for everyone

- Rabbi Shulman qualifies:
 - This is for someone who is able to go without sleep—no expectation to “torture yourself.”

C. Experiencing the seder as personal redemption

- Inner posture Rabbi Shulman stresses:
 - One should think/feel **כאילו הוא יצא ממצרים**
(as if he personally is leaving Egypt now).
- Mood:
 - The night’s actions should be done with **שמחה גדולה** (great joy).

D. Strengthening “הלל ושירה” at the point of fatigue

- Rabbi Shulman notes a practical challenge:
 - By הלל time people are tired; wine/food weigh on them.
 - His recommendation:
 - Be **מחזיק** the family before הלל by explaining what is happening and helping everyone approach with energy and intention—so it is done **כראוי**הלל.
 - Goal:
 - Singing with a **clear mouth** about the redemption:
 - “בשפה ברורה על הגאולה שגאלנו”
(with clear speech about the redemption with which He redeemed us.)
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V. Closing: marking the end of the section (11:30)

A. Concluding note

- Rabbi Shulman closes this unit with:
 - “עד כאן ההגדה של פסח”
(Until here is the Haggadah of Pesach.)
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In Summary

- Rabbi Shulman explains that **no eating or flavored drinking after the fourth cup** preserves טעם מצה, rooted in “אין מפטירים אחר הפסח אפיקומן.”
- The **third and fourth cups** are permitted despite being after the meal because they are **mitzvah-cups** (“שאני התם, דמצוה הם”).
- **Water** is generally permitted as it lacks taste, while **wine or other flavored drinks** are prohibited beyond the required cups.
- The seder’s goal is not only halachic precision but living the night with **simchah, personal identification with redemption, and energized הלל ושירה**, ideally extending through the night for those who can.